Planning Ahead for Mom, One Step at a Time

Your family's part, in order: eleven actions, with a line for who does each and by when.

The goal: a clear, dated picture of how Mom is doing today, the help she already has, what she has told you she wants, and the questions that are still open, each with a name beside it.

There's no clock on this. Share the list, put a name and a rough date next to each action, and tick it when it's done. Go at the pace that suits Mom.

ACTION	WHO	BY WHEN	DONE
1. Ask Mom how she feels things are going, and whether she's comfortable with the family writing a few things down. Write down what she says.			
2. List the diagnoses and ongoing conditions you know about, and who told you each one.			
3. Write out her medications and treatments with her, as one list. Change nothing.			
4. Over an ordinary week or two, note what she does on her own: bathing and dressing, meals, housework, shopping, bills and mail.			
5. Note how she gets around, at home and out, whether she drives and where, and any falls during the past year.			
6. Write down what anyone has noticed about her memory, as what they saw and when.			
7. List everyone who helps her now, family or paid, with what they do and roughly when it started.			
8. Write down what has changed during the past year, with a rough date beside each change.			
9. Talk with Mom about where she'd prefer to receive care, how important staying at home is, what she'd expect from family, and who she wants involved. Write her answers in her own words.			
10. Write down the kinds of care you want to learn about (home care, adult day programs, assisted living, memory care, skilled nursing) and the names of a few local providers. Names only, for now.			

ACTION	WHO	BY WHEN	DONE
11. Next to each open question, write who it goes to: Mom, her doctor, her pharmacist, a local care provider or your Medicaid planner.			

You're done when

How Mom is doing today, the help she already has, what she has told you she wants, the kinds of care you want to learn about and your open questions are all written down, with a date on the page and a name beside each question. What comes after that isn't on this list: weighing care options, looking at what care costs, and agreeing which changes would call for a fresh look. Those aren't the family's to do alone.

If it stalls

- Don't fill a gap by guessing. “We don't know yet” is a finished line.
- If Mom would rather not talk about part of this, leave that part. The rest of the list still works.
- If you notice something that seems to need attention sooner, don't save it for this list. Call her doctor's office.

What this plan doesn't do

It organizes your part. It doesn't certify that Mom is safe at home, decide what care she needs now or later, or stand in for the professionals it prepares you to talk with. Nothing here is medical, legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You've worked through your family's part and written down what you found. The care interview goes through Mom's situation area by area with you, so nothing important is overlooked, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›